

STEM the mental rot, optimise minds

In India, education is another name for competition. But **the gap** between demand and supply of seats in institutions, especially state-funded ones, **is brutal**. It gets wider at **elite** institutions like IITs, IIMs and NLU. Even for those who survive the entrance **ordeal**, there's more to follow.

Crushing academic pressure **deepens** under-confidence, mental health struggles and **isolation**, especially among students from **disadvantaged** backgrounds. Too many, unable to **bear the weight**, **snap** - many taking things to the limit and attempting/**committing** suicide. But much before this stage is reached, learning capacities **take a beating** because of **debilitating** performance anxiety.



Which is why **steps** like IIT-KGP's latest move to relax rules to balance academics and well-being, and BITS Pilani-Goa adding stress management to its syllabus, **are** welcome. These **tragedies**, as the Supreme Court said in March, **underscore** the urgent need for a more responsive system to **address** factors that push students towards mental stress reaching a **breaking point**.

Calling it a 'suicide **epidemic**', the top court ordered the formation of a task force to tackle the campus mental health crisis. NCRB data show students **made up** 7.6% of total suicides in 2022, with 1.2% linked to career problems, and 1.2% to exam failure. Weak **grievance redressal** systems leave students **vulnerable** to academic **harassment** and discrimination, while many institutions lack urgent **intervention mechanisms** for those showing signs of **distress**.

Easing the rat race **is** an **imperative**. HEIs must rethink **rigid evaluation** systems and invest in building safer, more welcoming campuses. And this is not only about **stemming** self-harm. It is also about **extracting** the best out of able minds to **optimise** their talents.

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

Vocabulary

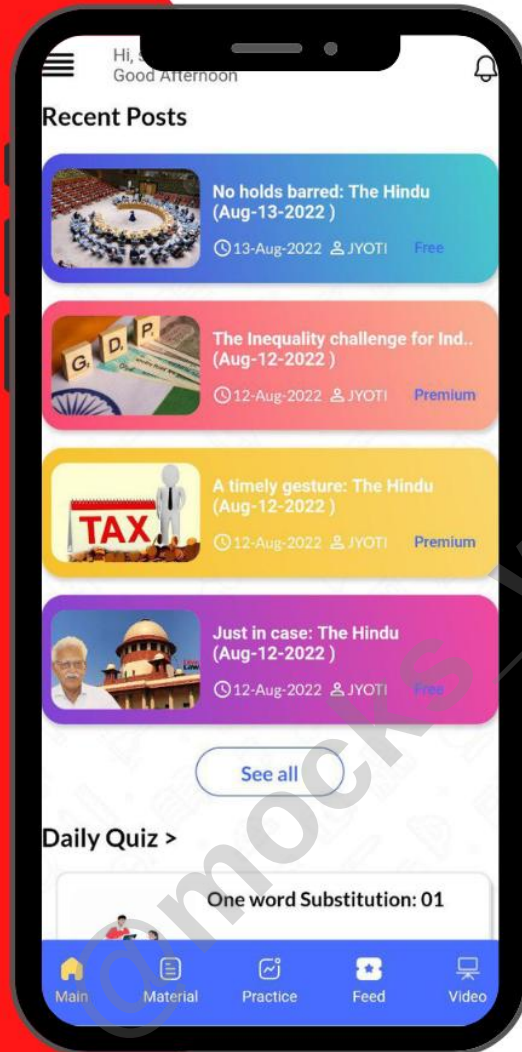
1. **Stem the rot** (phrase) – stop decline, halt deterioration, arrest decay, prevent worsening, curb damage गिरावट को रोकना
2. **Brutal** (adjective) – cruel, harsh, severe, ruthless, violent क्रूर / निर्मम
3. **Elite** (adjective) – top, select, privileged, high-ranking, exclusive उच्च वर्ग / विशिष्ट
4. **Ordeal** (noun) – hardship, trial, struggle, suffering, challenge दुखद अनुभव
5. **Deepen** (verb) – intensify, worsen, aggravate, escalate, heighten गहरा करना
6. **Isolation** (noun) – loneliness, seclusion, separation, detachment, exclusion अलगाव
7. **Disadvantaged** (adjective) – underprivileged, deprived, marginalized, needy, poor वंचित
8. **Bear the weight** (phrase) – endure pressure, carry burden, tolerate stress, manage strain, withstand load बोझ उठाना
9. **Snap** (noun) – breakdown, collapse, outburst, crack, rupture मानसिक टूट / झटका
10. **Commit** (verb) – perform (an act), carry out, execute, perpetrate, enact करना (अपराध या आत्महत्या जैसे कृत्य के लिए)
11. **Take a beating** (phrase) – suffer, be damaged, decline, weaken, deteriorate बुरी तरह प्रभावित होना
12. **Debilitate** (verb) – weaken, exhaust, enfeeble, drain, impair कमजोर कर देना
13. **Underscore** (verb) – emphasize, highlight, stress, point out, reinforce ज़ोर देना
14. **Address** (verb) – deal with, tackle, handle, respond to, confront समाधान करना
15. **Breaking point** (noun) – limit, threshold, crisis point, boiling point, snapping point सहने की अंतिम सीमा
16. **Epidemic** (noun) – outbreak, surge, spread, crisis, plague महामारी
17. **Make up** (phrasal verb) – constitute, comprise, form, account for, consist of बनना
18. **Grievance** (noun) – complaint, objection, injustice, dissatisfaction, concern शिकायत
19. **Redressal** (noun) – remedy, resolution, settlement, rectification, compensation समाधान
20. **Vulnerable** (adjective) – exposed, defenseless, unprotected, sensitive, weak असुरक्षित

21. **Harassment** (noun) – bullying, intimidation, persecution, abuse, mistreatment उत्पीड़न
22. **Intervention** (noun) – interference, involvement, action, mediation, intercession हस्तक्षेप
23. **Mechanism** (noun) – system, process, structure, method, setup तंत्र / प्रणाली
24. **Distress** (noun) – suffering, anguish, misery, anxiety, pain मानसिक पीड़ा
25. **The rat race** (phrase) – competitive struggle, grind, routine competition, survival race, relentless contest प्रतिस्पर्धा

26. **Imperative** (noun) – necessity, urgency, essential, requirement, obligation अत्यावश्यकता
27. **Rigid** (adjective) – strict, inflexible, unyielding, firm, unbending सख्त / कठोर
28. **Evaluation** (noun) – assessment, appraisal, analysis, review, judgment मूल्यांकन
29. **Stem** (verb) – Stop, curtail, halt, restrict, lessen, reduce रोकना
30. **Extract** (verb) – derive, obtain, draw out, harness, retrieve प्राप्त करना
31. **Optimise** (verb) – maximize, enhance, improve, refine, perfect सर्वोत्तम बनाना

Summary of the Editorial

1. Education in India is largely seen as a high-stakes competition, especially in STEM and professional fields.
2. Demand-supply gap in seats, especially in state-funded and elite institutions (IITs, IIMs, NLUs), is significant.
3. Students face intense pressure both before and after entering these institutions.
4. Academic stress severely impacts students' confidence, mental health, and social well-being.
5. Disadvantaged students are especially vulnerable to mental health struggles.
6. Some students succumb to pressure, leading to tragic outcomes like suicide.
7. Before such extremes, learning capacity often deteriorates due to performance anxiety.
8. Positive steps are being taken: IIT Kharagpur has relaxed rules to support well-being.
9. BITS Pilani-Goa has introduced stress management in its curriculum.
10. Supreme Court acknowledged a 'suicide epidemic' and ordered a task force for campus mental health.
11. NCRB data (2022) shows students formed 7.6% of total suicides, with 1.2% due to career issues and 1.2% to exam failures.
12. Grievance redressal systems in colleges are often weak or ineffective.
13. Lack of mental health support means many at-risk students are not helped in time.
14. Reforms in evaluation systems and reducing competitive intensity are essential.
15. Objective must shift to nurturing minds and optimizing talent, not just preventing harm.



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